Two days after Shelton's crushing defeat, the Envoy received an initial delegation of rebels who came seeking an unconditional British surrender. As Macnaghten put it himself, in a note found on his desk after his death,

> At my initiation, deputies were sent from the Rebels who came into cantonment on the 25th, I having received overtures from them of a pacific nature on the basis of our evacuating the country. I proposed to them the only terms which in my opinion could be accepted with honour. They returned me a letter of defiance the next morning to the effect that unless I consented to surrender our arms and to abandon His Majesty to his fate, we must prepare for imminent hostilities. To this I replied that we preferred death to dishonour and that it would remain with a higher power to decide between us.[92]

Macnaghten having refused to hand over Shuja and his family to Akbar Khan, and having broken off relations, there followed a further fortnight of hungry and anxious inactivity on the part of the British. Macnaghten was now pinning his strategy on the faint hope that a relief force from either Jalalabad, Ghazni or Kandahar might rescue the demoralised troops in the cantonments. To MacGregor, the Political Officer attached to General Sale's brigade in Jalalabad, he appealed repeatedly: 'Dozens of letters have been written, urging your immediate return with Sale's Brigade to Kabul, and if you have not started by the time you receive this, I earnestly beg that you will do so immediately. Our situation is a very precarious one; but with your assistance we shall all do well, and you must render it to us if you have any regard for our lives or the honour of our country.'[93]

The last messenger to make it through the Khord Kabul Pass, however, carried the news that Sale was himself hopelessly besieged and outnumbered in Jalalabad and in no position to relieve Kabul; he also reported that the Khyber had been lost and was now closed to any potential relief force attempting to make its way up from Peshawar. On 7 December, after thick snow had blocked the route, it became clear that no help was likely to make it through from Kandahar either, at least until the spring thaw. On the morning of the 8th Macnaghten heard from the last remaining garrison, Ghazni, that they too were besieged and unable to come to the aid of their compatriots in Kabul.[94] Now, with only one day's provisions left, there was no hope. Imminent starvation loomed. The military leadership remained paralysed. Elphinstone and Shelton both seemed locked in despair. The defeated and hungry troops were on the verge of mutiny. The numbers of the Afghan resistance were now estimated at over 50,000, outnumbering the British garrison about ten to one.